against enemies. The *sabhai* or *mandram* was the highest court of justice presided by the king himself. Every village had its own *mandram* which met at a common public place and was involved in organizing village and community activities. Warriors were respected, and a man who died in battle would have memorial stones erected in his honour and be worshipped in death. Even if a warrior dies in battle field with a wound in his back, it is considered derogatory in 'Sangam' traditions.

Lots of good practices of war find their mention in sangam literature. *Purananooru*, a sangam literature, hails the Pandyan king who announces all the women, children, sick and elderly people, cattles, to move to safety zone before invading a country. The idea of *justice* formed the conscience of State and king. Justice is an essential element in a king's rule. A good king should never sacrifice justice. Just rule and good deeds always will bring everlasting fame to the king. An important political principle that prevailed was that

(Despite the nature of political system being monarchy) the legitimacy of the king rests with the consent of the people and as long as he enjoyed people's support and he would loses legitimacy if he lost their support. Sangam literature (*Pattinappaalai*) speaks about different types of taxations like customs duty, income tax, toll tax etc as specific source of revenue to the State. Tamil kings and chieftains ruled the land with simple administrative structure of council of ministers, subordinates and administrative officers. There were officers to deal with foreign trade and customs revenue which was an important part of the budget. Pandya inscriptions mention about officers for pearl fisheries (*kalatika*) and the chief scribes (*kanatikan*). In flags and coins, the Cholas were represented by the tiger, the Cheras by the bow and arrow the Pandyas by the fish and the Pallavas by the lion.

The institution of 'spy' was considered as a necessary institution and the maintenance of peace and stability in the kingdom depended on the effectiveness of this institution. Though slavery as a form of institution was absent yet capturing of slaves after invasions, and slave trade or exchange for gifts did remain as practice among the rulers to undertake construction and building works.

The practice of caste system or *jati* was unknown among ancient Tamils. The idea and concept of class with differences in status based on professional distinctions did prevail. The caste system was alien and unknown to Sangam society. The division of society based on class has been revealed by the Sangam poets who mention about social categories (*kudi*): *tudiyan*, *panan*, and *kadamban*; or *arasar* (rulers), *vaishyar* (traders), and *velalar* (farmers). Differences in status were accepted as inevitable, yet *varna* in the form of caste or *jati* seems to be little known to Sangam society.

Though social stratification did prevail yet legitimization of *Manusmiriti* or *Aryan-Brahminical* interpretation of caste as divine arrangement was not integral to the cultural universe or worldview of the ancient Tamils. The beginnings and early inroads of the Aryan-Brahminical account of caste could be traced to later period of Sangam era. The ancient religion of Tamils was based on folk traditions. The worship of nature and natural elements were more common. The worship of Murugan Seyon among the tribes of Tamil Nadu and the cult worship of Murugan as the warrior God was based on folk culture. An earthly composition



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